

Arabian Desert

Arabian Peninsula



Area 900,000 sq miles (2.3 million sq km)

Annual rainfall 1–2 in (25–50 mm)

Average highest temperature 120°F (49°C)

Average lowest temperature 32°F (0°C)

The hot deserts of the Arabian Peninsula contain the vast Empty Quarter—an area of dunes the size of France. Less arid parts support sparse scrub and small mammals such as jerboas, which are hunted by deadly vipers. The rare Arabian oryx is among the desert's larger animals.



▲ SEA OF SAND

Vast dunes fringe the Empty Quarter—the world's largest sand desert.

Sonoran Desert

Southwestern United States



Area 108,000 sq miles (275,000 sq km)

Annual rainfall 3–10 in (75–250 mm)

Average highest temperature 119°F (48°C)

Average lowest temperature 32°F (0°C)

This is one of several neighboring deserts in the southwestern United States and Mexico. It is famous for cacti such as the giant saguaro cactus, although the most common plant is the strong-smelling creosote bush. Desert tortoises, pocket mice, kit foxes, bighorn sheep, and elf owls are among the wildlife.

Namib Desert

Southwest Africa



Area 81,000 sq miles (31,000 sq km)

Annual rainfall 0.2–3 in (5–75 mm)

Average highest temperature 113°F (45°C)

Average lowest temperature 32°F (0°C)



This narrow strip of desert gets most of its moisture from fog rolling in from the Atlantic Ocean. Moisture is gathered by long-leaved welwitschia plants, and by beetles that allow the fog to condense onto their cool bodies at night. This web-footed gecko is another Namib inhabitant.

Kalahari Desert

Southern Africa



Area 275,000 sq miles (712,250 sq km)

Annual rainfall 6–10 in (150–250 mm)

Average highest temperature 115°F (46°C)

Average lowest temperature 32°F (0°C)

Although parts of the Kalahari are true desert, many areas are dry savanna with thorn scrub and acacia trees. This is the home of the meerkat, plus larger animals such as wildebeests and flocks of flamingos that gather on floodwaters after rain.

Gobi Desert

Mongolia and northern China



Area 500,000 sq miles (1.3 million sq km)

Annual rainfall 0.4–10 in (10–250 mm)

Average highest temperature 113°F (45°C)

Average lowest temperature -40°F (-40°C)

The continental climate of the Gobi Desert creates temperature extremes that make life very difficult. Despite this, grasses and scattered low shrubs support animals such as desert hamsters, wild asses, gazelles, and wild two-humped Bactrian camels.

Great Victoria Desert

Southern Australia



Area 150,000 sq miles (338,500 sq km)

Annual rainfall 6–10 in (150–250 mm)

Average highest temperature 104°F (40°C)

Average lowest temperature 64°F (18°C)

Much of the interior of Australia is desert, with vast expanses of red sand and bare rock, dotted with scrub and tussock grass. The Great Victoria Desert is known for its many reptiles, including the ant-eating thorny devil lizard, the powerful sand goanna, and a variety of venomous snakes.

► DESERT PEA

Sturt's desert pea is a plant famous for its striking blood-red, black-centered flowers.

